

THE LAST PANEL

Game Concept & Core Mechanics

Team: Syntax Error

THE CONCEPT

Aren investigates a missing-child case through photographs, recorded moments, and fragments of memory. The player can enter these memories and use **Living Ink** to interfere with the order of events. The investigation is therefore not passive: the player changes the conditions under which clues can be discovered.

CORE GAMEPLAY LOOP

- **Investigate:** examine photographs, locations and recorded moments for evidence.
- **Enter memory:** reconstruct the relevant event and observe its normal sequence.
- **Read the light:** the game uses location, date and time to estimate the Sun's position.
- **Use Living Ink:** choose a colour and disturb the memory's order.
- **Handle instability:** Ink can fluctuate or create disturbances during use.
- **Reveal clues:** changed timing, movement, shadows or interactions can expose hidden information.
- **Manage Pen Credits:** every intervention has a cost, so power must be used deliberately.

THE CENTRAL MECHANIC — LIVING INK

Ink is the game's main resource and interaction system. Its effectiveness and cost are influenced by the world around the player. The player must learn when to use it, which colour to choose, and whether the result is worth the Pen Credits spent.

Input / Rule	Effect in the game
Player location	Provides the geographic reference for the solar calculation.
Date & time	Determines the relevant solar condition.
Sun position	When the Sun is directly or relatively near the relevant position, Ink usage becomes higher.
Sun not near	Ink follows its normal usage/cost rule.
Ink fluctuation	The Ink may fluctuate or create disturbances while being used, adding controlled uncertainty.
Pen Credits	More significant/demanding Ink effects can consume more of the limited resource.

COLOUR & ORDER DISRUPTION

Colour is the language of the Ink. Different colours break the order of a memory in different ways. Some can make events feel slower; others can accelerate movement or alter how a sequence unfolds. The player does not initially know which colour is best for every situation and learns through experimentation.

Colour is primarily the imaginative expression of the power; the important gameplay rule is what each colour does to the **order of events**, and how much that intervention costs.

LIGHT & SHADOW

Light is part of the puzzle system, not merely visual atmosphere. Real-world solar information can influence the game's virtual light and Ink behaviour. Shadows, reflections, timing and illumination can become evidence.

Example: a shadow crosses a scene at a specific moment. By applying the appropriate Ink effect, the player can alter its timing and expose a detail that was hidden in the original sequence.

THE LAST PANEL — SYSTEM & STORY

Syntax Error

ADDITIONAL GAME MECHANICS

Mechanic	Role
Memory Reconstruction	Photographs and recordings become interactive memories rather than simple cutscenes.
Cause & Effect	Changing one part of a sequence can change what becomes visible later.
Light & Shadow	Lighting conditions can reveal or conceal evidence.
Colour Discovery	Players learn colour behaviour through experimentation.
Ink Instability	Power use can fluctuate, creating disturbances the player must recognise.
Pen Credits	Limited resources prevent unlimited manipulation and make each intervention meaningful.
Environmental Evidence	Object positions, reflections, shadows, movement and timing can all become clues.

SAMPLE PUZZLE

- 1. Aren finds a photograph connected to the missing-child case.
- 2. The photograph opens a reconstructed memory with a fixed sequence of events.
- 3. The game establishes the relevant solar condition and virtual light/shadow.
- 4. Aren chooses an Ink colour to disturb the sequence.
- 5. The Ink may fluctuate, creating a controlled disturbance during the intervention.
- 6. A changed shadow, movement or event reveals a previously hidden detail.
- 7. Pen Credits are consumed; the player decides whether further investigation is worth the cost.

THE STORY

Aren is investigating the disappearance of a child while following a trail of memories that do not behave like ordinary memories. A rival detective appears to be pursuing the same case, while a larger force seems to be guiding Aren toward particular moments.

As Aren goes deeper, the boundary between **discovering what happened** and **changing what happened** becomes increasingly uncertain. The Living Ink is not merely a tool for viewing the past; it can interfere with the order that holds a memory together.

THE TWIST — WITHOUT SPOILING IT

The investigation, the rival detective, the Living Ink and the force guiding Aren are connected. The player should discover that connection gradually rather than receive the final explanation upfront.

The central question is: **if Aren can change the order of a memory, where is the boundary between uncovering the past and becoming part of the reason that past exists?**

TECHNICAL DIRECTION — GODOT

- **Godot:** controls virtual lighting, shadows, animation timing, colour effects, memory states and resource costs.
- **Location:** with permission, the game can obtain geographic information on supported platforms.
- **Solar calculation:** location + date/time can determine an approximate Sun direction/elevation.
- **Fallback:** if location is unavailable, use a selectable city/default location so puzzles remain playable and testable.
- **Design principle:** real-world sunlight enhances the game but should never be required for story progress.

THE GAME IN ONE LINE

Investigate memories, manipulate their order with Living Ink, use light to uncover what is hidden, and decide how much of the past you are willing to disturb.

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